

AI-Designed Portrait Guide #011

Difficulty **Advanced** Est. time **10-14 hours** Subject **Portrait / Figure Study**

Pencils **Prismacolor Premier**

• COLOR PALETTE



Beige Sienna

PC1080

Primary warm skin base tone; mid-value, golden undertone (7.3% of image)



Light Umber

PC941

Secondary skin midtone; warm brown for depth and form modeling (7.4%)



50% Warm Grey

PC1054

Skin undertone and blending layer; establishes warm grey foundation (8%)



Clay Rose

PC1017

Warm accent for cheeks, nose tip, and glow areas; mid-saturation rose-brown



Espresso

PC1099

Dark hair base and deep shadow anchor; warm dark brown (6.4%)



90% French Grey

PC1076

Very dark anchor for depth; use in hair core and deepest shadows only (6.9%)



90% Warm Grey

PC1058

Deep shadow tone; warm grey shadow color, never neutral (4.6%)



70% Warm Grey

PC1056

Mid-value shadow and form accent; transitions between lights and darks (4.7%)



20% Cool Grey

PC1060

Cool light and background; provides subtle cool shift to light zones (7.8%)



Cobalt Blue Hue

PC133

Clothing primary color; saturated blue dominant in garment (16.7%)



Dioxazine Purple Hue

PC132

Clothing shadow and depth; dark purple-blue for fabric shadows (10.3%)



Bronze

PC1028

Warm brown transitional mixer; bridges skin and hair (6.8%, treat as mixing)



Peach

PC939

Warm light highlight; light peachy tone for lit planes and luminous areas



20% Warm Grey

PC1051

Light blending layer; soften transitions between warm tones



White

PC938

Burnishing medium and final peak highlight; reserved for brightest small accents



Putty Beige

PC1083

Warm neutral for gentle transitions; bridges skin and background



Ginger Root

PC1084

Warm light accent in highlights and lit forehead area



Rosy Beige

PC1019

Soft warm accent for cheeks and nose; adds blush without harshness

• VISUAL ANALYSIS

SUBJECT IDENTIFICATION

What is the subject? Male figure, young adult (mid-20s to early 30s), medium-deep skin tone with warm golden-olive undertones (measured $L^* \approx 53/100$). Dark hair and visible facial hair (beard/stubble). Upper body visible, wearing saturated blue clothing. Frontal-facing head position, relatively neutral expression.

Material characteristics Photorealistic reference; soft, even illumination typical of studio or indoor frontal light. Skin reads as matte, non-reflective except for highlight peaks on nose bridge and forehead. Hair has volume and directional flow. Clothing fabric is matte, saturated blue.

Geometric structure Head tilts slightly; face is roughly frontal with slight three-quarter angle apparent in the away-side cheekbone and jaw. Chin is prominent. Neck transitions from jaw to shoulders with visible form. Eyes are level; nose is centerline; mouth line approximately horizontal but natural variation in lip thickness.

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

Light source direction Soft, diffuse frontal light—likely overhead or slightly elevated, creating modest form shadows without dramatic side-lighting. Light is warm-toned, not cool or high-contrast.

HIGHLIGHT

Forehead apex and bridge, nose tip, highest plane of cheekbones—all read as warm-lit peaks with yellow-cream tendency. These should be TRUE highlights (maximum value jump from surrounding midtone), not just lighter midtone.

LIGHT AREA

Upper half of face, lit planes of cheeks, upper forehead, lit side of nose—these are warm, mid-to-light value, not saturated.

MIDTONE

Central face, transition zones between lit and shadow, inner eye areas, cheeks' center—these carry the primary warm-grey and warm-brown skin base.

SHADOW

Under jaw, under-nose shadow (nasolabial folds), eye sockets and upper-lid cast shadow, away-side cheek and jaw plane, neck underside. Shadows are WARM-GREY and mid-value, NOT heavy darks or cool-neutral greys.

CAST SHADOW

Under chin and jaw onto neck; modest, warm-grey, not a dark blob. Subtle reflected light bounces inside this shadow, preventing it from reading as a hole.

Edge quality notes

All edges are soft and integrated; no hard outlines. Skin-to-hair transitions are gradual. Clothing-to-neck edge is soft but clear. Upper lash line is the single sharpest edge in the face, but even this should remain integrated, never poster-like.

COLOR ANALYSIS

Overall temperature

WARM throughout. Skin is warm golden-olive, not cool or neutral. Hair carries warm dark brown (espresso, bronze) not pure cool black. Shadows are WARM greys, not cool blue-greys or neutral greys. Even the cool grey in the background (#E4E9EF, PC1060) reads as cool only in comparison; it is not a strong cool.

Light zone tendency

Lit planes shift toward warm peach (#F1A78D PC939), cream, and warm light beige (PC1084 Ginger Root). Forehead and nose tip especially bright, leaning yellow-cream.

Shadow zone tendency

Shadow zones shift toward warm grey (PC1056, PC1058, PC1051) and warm brown (PC1028 Bronze as an underglaze). Avoid neutral grey or cool blue-grey in shadows; keep them distinctly warm. This is critical for maintaining the warm light and preventing the face from reading as cold.

Special color areas

Cheeks and nose tip: warm red-rose undertone (PC1017 Clay Rose, PC1019 Rosy Beige) punched through midtone to signal health and frontal light strike. Beard/facial hair: graduated from dark espresso at core (chin, jawline) to sparse individual hairs with skin showing through at edges (cheeks, sideburn area). Clothing: saturated blue (PC133 Cobalt Blue, PC132 Dioxazine for shadows) is a significant color mass (~27% of image per measurements); keep it warm-lit on upper chest, deeper (darker blue with purple undertone) in folds and self-shadows.

Saturation distribution

Moderate saturation overall. Skin is warm but not vivid; clothing blue is the most saturated single color. Beard is desaturated (warm grey-brown, not pure black). Hair carries warm and cool greys within its mass, not monochrome. Cheeks are warm but soft, not hot pink.

• STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

01 Step 1: Value Structure & Light Hierarchy Assessment

Entire face and upper body

Visual assessment and reference study

N/A pressure

Before laying pencil, study the reference and identify the full value range: the brightest highlights (forehead apex, nose bridge/tip, cheekbone peaks), the mid-lit planes (upper face, center cheeks), the mid-shadows (under jaw, eye sockets, away-side cheek), and the core/cast shadows (under chin, neck underside). Soft frontal light means no dramatic high-contrast side lighting, so rely on subtle modeling within a narrow value range—the entire face lives roughly between light midtone and mid-dark midtone, with only the brightest highlights and deepest shadows at the extremes. Establish where each zone sits on your value scale (1–10, where 10 is white and 1 is black). This mental map prevents blotchy, patchy rendering by establishing a hierarchy of where layers will sit.

✦ *Do not assume the shadow side of the face is a heavy dark mass. In soft frontal light, even the away-side cheekbone and jaw remain mid-value, just warmer-grey and slightly desaturated compared to the lit side. This is key to avoiding the flat, filled-in shadow-blob look that this artist's prior work exhibited.*

02 Step 2: Monochrome Value Underpainting (Solvent Wash Method)

Full face and neck

Solvent wash; light layer, brush spread, full dry before next layer

Light (barely visible pencil marks before solvent) pressure

Using PC1099 Espresso or PC1076 90% French Grey, lay down a very light, sparse layer across the entire face and neck—think of it as a value sketch, not a filled-in underpainting. Layer the pencil at extremely light pressure in circular motions, focusing the darkest tones into shadow zones (under jaw, eye sockets, away-side cheek). Keep the lit planes (forehead, nose, cheekbones) noticeably lighter even in this monochrome pass. Once this layer is dry, apply Gamsol or Zest-It with a small soft brush, working in sections, to liquify and spread the pigment like watercolor. Let it dry completely (5–10 minutes). This creates a blended, even value foundation and prevents pencil tooth from clogging too early.

COLORS

● PC1099 Espresso

● PC1076 90% French Grey

✦ *Sparse pigment + solvent = even spread; dense pigment + solvent = muddy, pasty mess. Use restraint. The wash should act as a tinted primer, not a filled-in rendering.*

03 Step 3: Base Warm Skin Tone Layer (Full Face & Neck)

Entire face, jaw, neck—no exceptions

Circular light-to-medium pressure blending, full-face pass

Light to Medium pressure

Layer PC1080 Beige Sienna and PC1054 50% Warm Grey across the entire face, jaw, and visible neck in thin, even passes at light-to-medium pressure. Use circular, overlapping strokes to blend these two colors together, creating a warm, slightly grey skin foundation. Do NOT zone or deepen—this pass treats the whole face as one unified mid-value. Avoid the eye whites, lips, and brightest highlight peaks (forehead apex, nose tip). This step unifies the whole face with a consistent warm undertone, preventing the blotchy area-by-area rendering that plagued prior work. The goal is an even wash, not local depth yet.

COLORS ● PC1080 Beige Sienna ● PC1054 50% Warm Grey

✦ *Treat this as a landscape artist would treat an underpainting sky—one unified color across the entire plane first, before adding local variation. Resist the urge to deepen shadows here; that comes later. Evenness is the goal.*

04 Step 4: Eye Rendering—Pupil, Iris & Shadow Construction

Both eyes; iris and pupil

Solid pupil + cast shadow (dark anchor); radial iris strokes (outward); light lower iris and sclera; white highlight (single point only)

Heavy (pupil), Medium (iris), Light (sclera) pressure

Establish the deepest dark in the portrait: the pupil and upper-lid cast shadow. Using PC1076 90% French Grey or PC1099 Espresso at medium-to-heavy pressure, fill the pupil as a solid dark circle, leaving a tiny white specular highlight (single point, upper-left quadrant of iris, reserved by not touching it). Layer the cast shadow from the upper eyelid over the upper iris, darkening that zone. Once the pupil is locked in, build the iris using radial strokes from the pupil outward (working outward, NOT inward—outward strokes follow light refraction). Use PC941 Light Umber, PC1054 50% Warm Grey, and PC1017 Clay Rose in thin radial layers to suggest iris structure; radial layers create dimension and a reflective quality that flat fills cannot. Keep the lower iris lighter and warmer than the upper iris (light-struck zone). The sclera (white of eye) is never pure white—use PC1060 20% Cool Grey or PC1051 20% Warm Grey for the sclera body, reserving PC938 White only for the specular highlight and a tiny arc of reflected light at the lower limbus (eye edge).

COLORS ● PC1076 90% French Grey ● PC1099 Espresso ● PC941 Light Umber

● PC1054 50% Warm Grey

● PC1017 Clay Rose

● PC1060 20% Cool Grey

● PC1051 20% Warm Grey

● PC938 White

✦ *The upper lash line is the single darkest edge in the whole face—make it decisive and sharp. The lower lash line is softer and more diffuse; do not mirror the upper. Radial iris strokes are not random; they follow the direction light travels through the eye, creating a wet, glassy quality.*

05 Step 5: Eye Rendering—Upper & Lower Lashes, Tear Duct Detail

Lash lines and eye corners

Sharp pencil; upper lash line is crisp and dark, lower is soft and light; stipple and texture, not line-work

Heavy (upper lash), Light (lower lash & tear duct) pressure

Using a sharp PC1099 Espresso or PC1076 90% French Grey pencil, define the upper lash line with a crisp, slightly curved stroke that is darkest at the center and tapers slightly at the outer corner. Individual lashes are suggested (not drawn individually) by light stipple marks and subtle stroke variations—the lash line mass reads as a texture, not a series of hairs. The lower lash line is lighter and softer; apply at light pressure and allow it to blend slightly into the lower lids, never a hard dark line. Add a touch of PC1017 Clay Rose or PC1019 Rosy Beige at the inner tear duct and just inside the lower lash line to add warmth and flesh tone. Avoid over-rendering—restraint reads as realism; heavy rendering reads as illustration.

COLORS ☒ PC1099 Espresso ☒ PC1076 90% French Grey ☒ PC1017 Clay Rose
☒ PC1019 Rosy Beige

✦ *The upper lash line and its cast shadow are the two darkest lines in portraiture—they sell the eye's depth instantly. Do not soften the upper lash line; leave it defined.*

06 Step 6: Facial Hair Base—Graduated Density & Directional Placement

Chin, jaw, cheeks, and sideburn area; graduated from dense to sparse

Dense circular strokes at chin/jaw (core); sparse stipple and directional lines on cheeks (edges); graduated density creates form

Heavy (jaw core), Medium (transition), Light (cheek edges) pressure

Facial hair (beard/stubble) is visible in this reference and must be rendered with graduated density, not as a flat dark blob. The beard is densest at the chin and lower jaw (dark espresso, medium-to-heavy pressure with PC1099 Espresso or PC1028 Bronze mixed). As you move upward toward the cheeks and sideburns, thin the density dramatically—individual hairs become visible, skin shows through, and color transitions to a warm grey (PC1054 or PC1056). Use directional strokes that follow the actual growth direction (downward and slightly outward from the jaw). Layer the dense core first in overlapping circular strokes at the chin and jaw; then, moving to the cheeks, switch to stipple-and-sparse-line technique, leaving gaps where facial skin (PC1080, PC1054) is visible between the hairs. This graduated approach prevents the beard from reading as a shape stuck on the face—it reads as hair growing from skin.

COLORS

● PC1099 Espresso

● PC1028 Bronze

● PC1054 50% Warm Grey

● PC1056 70% Warm Grey

● PC1080 Beige Sienna

✦ *The single biggest mistake in rendering facial hair is treating it as a uniform dark texture. Real stubble is a gradient: dense and dark where it anchors (chin), thinning and sparse where it catches light (cheek and jaw edges). Use this gradient as a form-modeling tool; it helps define the jaw's undercurve.*

07 Step 7: Shadow Zones & Form Modeling—Under-Jaw & Neck Cast Shadow

Underside of jaw, neck, and cast shadow onto upper chest

Warm grey shadow layering; soft edge on transitions; reflected light lift inside shadow

Medium (shadow core), Light (reflected light and edges) pressure

Begin depth modeling by establishing the cast shadow and form shadow in the neck and under-jaw zone. Using PC1058 90% Warm Grey and PC1056 70% Warm Grey at medium pressure, layer the under-jaw shadow and the cast shadow from the jaw onto the neck and upper chest. Keep this shadow warm and mid-value (not a heavy dark)—it should read as a soft modeling shadow, not a black hole. The shadow should be softest and lightest on the upper chest where it transitions into reflected light. Inside this shadow zone, add a touch of warm reflected light using PC1051 20% Warm Grey or a very light PC1054 to suggest light bouncing up from the clothing. This prevents the shadow from reading as flat and keeps the form turning convincingly. The neck itself should be slightly darker than the face (it receives less direct light and sits in partial shadow), but not dramatically so.

COLORS

● PC1058 90% Warm Grey

● PC1056 70% Warm Grey

● PC1051 20% Warm Grey

● PC1054 50% Warm Grey

✦ *Shadows that are too dark or too cool will make the face read as disconnected from the body. Keep shadow zones warm and mid-value; this single change elevates a flat face into a three-dimensional head.*

08 Step 8: Cheekbone & Jaw Plane Definition—The Away-Side Cheek

Away-side (shadow-side) cheek, jaw turn, and cheekbone edge

Warm grey plane layer; crisp but soft core-shadow edge at plane turn; plane-separation contrast

Light to Medium (plane), Medium (core-shadow edge) pressure

This step addresses the accumulated correction regarding away-side flatness. The away-side cheek must read as a form plane turning in warm light, not a flat dark smudge or a heavy ashy mass. Layer PC1054 50% Warm Grey + PC1056 70% Warm Grey across the away-side cheek at light-to-medium pressure, building a warm mid-value that is slightly cooler and more desaturated than the lit-side cheek. The critical move: define a crisp but soft core shadow along the cheekbone's edge (where the cheek plane turns away) using PC1028 Bronze or PC1099 Espresso at medium pressure. This edge should be darker than the surrounding away-side plane but still warm and integrated—never a hard line. The plane behind (away-side) this edge is lighter and reads as reflected light and ambient fill. This creates the illusion of the head turning, sculpting form without heavy modeling.

COLORS ☒ PC1054 50% Warm Grey ☒ PC1056 70% Warm Grey

☒ PC1028 Bronze ☒ PC1099 Espresso

✦ *The away-side cheek is where amateurs either flatten the face with no shadow or over-darken it into an ashy blob. The solution: treat it as a lit plane that is tilted away, not in shadow. It's warm, mid-value, and clearly defined by one crisp edge (the core-shadow turn). The area behind that edge remains readable and lit, not black.*

09 Step 9: Nose Structure & Warmth—Form & Highlight Prep

Nose: bridge, ball, tip, sides, and under-nose shadow

Layered warm tones for form; warm shadows (not cool); light pressure on bright zones; highlight preservation

Light to Medium (sides), Light (tip and highlight area) pressure

The nose is the highest point on the face and catches maximum light. Build form using layered warm tones: PC1080 Beige Sienna and PC941 Light Umber on the sides and bridge at light-to-medium pressure, defining the nose's width and depth. The ball of the nose and tip should be warm and light (PC939 Peach or PC1084 Ginger Root at light pressure) to signal direct light. The under-nose shadow (septum shadow and nostril underside) uses PC1056 70% Warm Grey or PC1058 90% Warm Grey at light pressure—keep it warm, not neutral, and avoid making the nostrils a heavy dark hole. A touch of PC1017 Clay Rose on the nostril rim and nose tip adds warmth and health. The nose bridge carries one of the portrait's peak highlights; leave this area light in early passes, preparing for a final bright accent in Step 16. By the end of this step, the nose should read as a three-dimensional form with warm, directional light.

COLORS

● PC1080 Beige Sienna

● PC941 Light Umber

● PC939 Peach

● PC1084 Ginger Root

● PC1056 70% Warm Grey

● PC1058 90% Warm Grey

● PC1017 Clay Rose

✦ *Many artists render noses as a hard-edged shape. The nose is sculpted by warm light, not outlined. Sides are darker warm; tip is lighter warm; under-nose is warm grey. No outlines; all soft edges.*

10 Step 10: Lip & Mouth Area—Upper/Lower Lip & Lip Line Definition

Lips, lip line, and surrounding mouth zone

Soft lip line; upper lip cool and desaturated; lower lip warm and saturated; fine creases last at light pressure

Light to Medium (lip color), Light (lip line and texture) pressure

The upper lip reads darker and cooler than the lower lip; the lower lip is lighter, warmer, and more saturated (it catches direct light and is the light-struck surface). Begin by establishing the lip line using a sharp PC1099 Espresso or PC1017 Clay Rose at light pressure—the line is soft and integrated, never a hard outline. The upper lip is rendered using PC1017 Clay Rose mixed with a touch of PC1056 70% Warm Grey at light-to-medium pressure, keeping it relatively desaturated and cool compared to the lower lip. The lower lip uses PC1019 Rosy Beige or PC939 Peach at light-to-medium pressure, warmer and slightly more saturated than the upper; this reads as the light-catching lip surface. Add fine horizontal texture creases to the lower lip at the very end with a sharp pencil and very light pressure—these creases follow the natural lip contours and suggest moisture and subtle form. The mouth corner (where lips meet) is kept soft and slightly darker; avoid making it a hard crease. Lip highlights are subtle and warm, not bright white.

COLORS



PC1099 Espresso



PC1017 Clay Rose



PC1056 70% Warm Grey



PC1019 Rosy Beige



PC939 Peach

✦ *Lips are a subtlety zone in modern portraiture. Avoid vivid or hot-pink lips (unless the reference supports it—this one does not). The upper lip's shadow and the lower lip's highlight relationship sculpts the mouth's form; texture and creases suggest real skin, not a graphic shape.*

11 Step 11: Hair Rendering—Dark Mass & Directional Foundation

Entire hair mass; roots, mid-lengths, and ends

Directional strokes following growth; dense darks between clumps; full-length strokes; preserve light areas

Medium to Heavy (dark mass), Light (transition zones) pressure

Hair is never pure black—it is built from dark warm and cool layers. Begin with the darkest areas (around the face, temples, and at the roots) using PC1099 Espresso and PC1076 90% French Grey at medium-to-heavy pressure, laying strokes in the direction hair actually grows (generally downward and outward from the crown, around the ears, and forward at the sideburns). Place the densest darks between hair clumps and in shadow zones (away-side and back of head). Full-length strokes (from roots to tips) establish the hair's mass and flow—never render every strand; render the light pattern across the whole mass instead. Layer the dark foundation first, preserving paper tooth and lighter areas for highlights in later steps. The hair at the crown and on the lit side should be noticeably lighter than the hair in shadow—this creates the illusion of volume and light striking the top of the head.

COLORS

● PC1099 Espresso

● PC1076 90% French Grey

● PC1028 Bronze

✦ *Hair rendering is a common weak point. The key is to think of hair as landscape—dark hills, light valleys, and a unified direction of flow. Individual strand rendering is the enemy of realism at this scale; work the whole mass and suggest individual hairs only in the final detail pass.*

12 Step 12: Hair Rendering—Tone Variation & Warm/Cool Transitions

Hair mid-tones and reflected light areas; crown and lit side

Directional mid-tone layering; warm on lit side, cool on away-side; blending in transitions; preserve sharp edges at light-shadow boundary

Light to Medium pressure

Layer warm and cool greys into the hair to build dimension. Using PC1054 50% Warm Grey, PC1056 70% Warm Grey, and a light touch of PC1084 Ginger Root or PC939 Peach on the lit side of the hair, add mid-tone layers over the dark foundation. These warmer tones suggest light streaming through the hair and catch highlights. The hair on the away-side can carry a touch of cool grey (PC1060 20% Cool Grey or PC1051 20% Warm Grey) to push it slightly back in space. Build these layers at light-to-medium pressure, working in the direction of hair growth. The goal is a hair mass that reads as textured and lit, not flat. Blend the transitions between darks and mid-tones using a colorless blender at light pressure for soft passages, preserving crisp dark-light edges where light and shadow meet (this edge is key to suggesting volume).

COLORS



PC1054 50% Warm Grey



PC1056 70% Warm Grey



PC1084 Ginger Root



PC939 Peach



PC1060 20% Cool Grey



PC1051 20% Warm Grey

✦ *Hair transitions are where the eye reads form and light. A crisp edge between a dark and a light strand reads as form; a soft blend reads as shadow. Use both strategically.*

13 Step 13: Neck Anatomy & Skin-to-Garment Transition

Neck: sides, front, self-shadow, and edge where neck meets clothing

Base color layer full neck; soft muscle definition; soft but defined edge at garment line; reflected color bounce from clothing

Light to Medium (neck base), Light (shadows and reflected color) pressure

The neck is a distinct form plane with its own anatomy. Layer PC1080 Beige Sienna + PC1054 50% Warm Grey across the front and sides of the neck at light pressure, establishing base color. The neck is typically slightly darker and more desaturated than the face because it receives less direct light and sits partly in shadow. Define the sternocleidomastoid muscle on each side with a soft shadow (PC1056 70% Warm Grey or PC1058 90% Warm Grey at light pressure) running from behind the ear down toward the collarbone—this reads as gentle form, not a hard line. The under-jaw/chin shadow (already begun in Step 7) should integrate seamlessly into the neck. Most importantly: where the neck meets the clothing (collar edge, neckline), create a soft but clear transition. The skin-to-garment edge is never hard, but it is visible; layer the garment color (PC133 Cobalt Blue Hue, PC132 Dioxazine Purple) up to this line without overrunning the skin. Subtle reflected light from the blue clothing can kiss the underside of the jaw and lower neck (a thin glaze of a very light desaturated blue-grey), making the color bounce convincing.

COLORS

● PC1080 Beige Sienna

● PC1054 50% Warm Grey

● PC1056 70% Warm Grey

● PC1058 90% Warm Grey

● PC133 Cobalt Blue Hue

● PC132 Dioxazine Purple Hue

✦ *The neck is often forgotten, but it is a critical transition zone. A neck that is rendered with the same value and warmth as the face looks pasted on. A neck that is slightly darker, more desaturated, and carefully integrated into the face and body reads as part of the whole figure.*

14 Step 14: Cool Undertones & Shadow Glazes—Unifying the Shadow Zones

Shadow zones across the entire face: under-chin, eye sockets, away-side cheek, under-nose, and any defined shadows

Light, transparent glaze over shadow zones only; does not overpower warm under-layers; unifies shadow family

Light (barely visible) pressure

Apply a light glaze of PC1060 20% Cool Grey or PC1051 20% Warm Grey over the shadow zones at very light pressure to add subtle cool undertone and unify the shadows (this step is critical for preventing shadows from reading as random dark patches). Do NOT glaze the lit planes; keep this glaze to true shadow areas only. The cool glaze should be transparent enough that the warm under-layers (PC1054, PC1056, PC1058) remain visible and dominant—the glaze is a thin veil, not opaque coverage. This creates the optical effect of cool light entering shadow (ambient fill from the sky or nearby cool surfaces), which is what real skin does. After this glaze, the entire shadow family should read as related and unified, not spotty. Blend this glaze gently with a colorless blender at very light pressure if any edges feel too hard.

COLORS



PC1060 20% Cool Grey



PC1051 20% Warm Grey

✦ *This glaze is invisible when done correctly—it is felt, not seen. If your cool glaze looks like a visible layer, you applied too much pressure. The goal is to nudge the temperature of shadows cool without changing their warmth fundamentally.*

15 Step 15: Warm Accent Layer—Cheeks, Nose Tip & Glow Emphasis

Cheeks (both), nose tip, and soft glow zones around eyes and temples

Soft, circular placement of warm colors; no outline; blend into surrounding midtone; emphasize form and light strike

Light to Medium pressure

Punch warm, slightly saturated accent colors into the cheeks and nose tip to signal health, frontal light strike, and roundness. Using PC1017 Clay Rose or PC1019 Rosy Beige at light-to-medium pressure, layer circular warm tones on the cheekbones (highest point of cheek bulge) with soft, blended edges. Do NOT outline the cheek; blend this color into the surrounding midtone. The nose tip receives a touch of PC1017 or PC939 Peach at light pressure to emphasize its form and light. Around the inner corner of the eyes and on the temples, a subtle touch of PC1084 Ginger Root or PC1051 20% Warm Grey adds warm glow (this is ambient/reflected warm light). These warm accents should feel glowing, not graphic or blotchy—use soft pressure and gentle blending with a colorless blender to integrate them seamlessly. The cheek accent is the single most important "pop" that signals a portrait is alive and lit; this step is non-negotiable.

COLORS ☐ PC1017 Clay Rose ☐ PC1019 Rosy Beige ☐ PC939 Peach
☐ PC1084 Ginger Root ☐ PC1051 20% Warm Grey

✦ *Cheek color is where amateurs often go wrong—too bright, too saturated, or too localized. Real cheek glow is soft, warm, slightly desaturated, and integrated into the face. It signals health and light, not a graphic circle.*

16 Step 16: Clothing & Garment Rendering—Blue Fabric Structure & Folds

Visible clothing: chest, shoulders, and neckline area

Light blue in lit areas, dark purple in shadows; directional strokes following fabric; warm grey in fold shadows; color bounce on neck

Light to Medium (lit areas), Medium (shadows and folds) pressure

The blue garment is a significant color mass (PC133 Cobalt Blue Hue in lit areas, PC132 Dioxazine Purple Hue in shadows and folds). Begin the clothing base using PC133 at light-to-medium pressure on the lit (upper) areas of the chest and shoulders, following the fabric's structure and fold direction. In shadow areas and deep folds (under the arms, around the neckline), layer PC132 Dioxazine Purple at medium pressure for depth. Do NOT render the clothing as flat color; suggest fabric weight and fold texture using slightly directional strokes that follow the garment's fall and drape. Add subtle warm grey (PC1054, PC1051) in the deepest folds to signal reflected light inside shadows (fabric does not absorb light into black holes; light bounces inside folds). The edge where clothing meets the neck is soft but defined; ensure the skin edge remains crisp and warm against the cool blue. A touch of very light desaturated cool (PC1060 or PC1051) on the upper chest near the neckline can suggest reflected warm skin-light bouncing up onto the lower jaw/neck—this color bounce makes the figure read as unified under a single light source.

COLORS

☒ PC133 Cobalt Blue Hue

☒ PC132 Dioxazine Purple Hue

☐ PC1054 50% Warm Grey

☐ PC1051 20% Warm Grey

☐ PC1060 20% Cool Grey

✦ *Clothing is often rendered as a flat shape. Real fabric reads as weight and light; the clothing surface turns and folds, catching light and shadow just as skin does. Fold shadows in fabric are rarely pure dark—they carry reflected light and ambient fill.*

17 Step 17: Final Highlights & Peak Lights—True Peaks & Value Jumps

Forehead apex, nose bridge and tip, cheekbone peaks, and any other maximum-light points

Light pressure, small precise placement, sharp edge where light is most direct, soft edge in transitions

Light pressure

This step directly addresses the accumulated correction regarding insufficient highlights. Build true peak highlights by adding a final bright accent layer to the brightest zones. Using PC938 White or PC1084 Ginger Root at light pressure, punch small, decisive highlights onto the forehead apex, the very tip of the nose, the peak of each cheekbone, and the upper surface of the lower lip. These highlights should create a clear, visible jump in value from the surrounding midtone—if your highlight looks like just a "lighter midtone," it is not bright enough. The key is restraint and precision: highlights are small, specific, and placed where light is most direct. A single point of white specular reflection on the eyes (already reserved in Step 4) is typically the only pure white. The nose tip and cheekbone peaks might reach near-white (PC1084 Ginger Root + light PC938 White blend) rather than pure white. Leave sharp edges on highlights where light is most direct; soften edges only in transition zones.

COLORS



PC938 White



PC1084 Ginger Root



PC939 Peach

✦ *Highlights are the single most common deficiency in colored-pencil portraiture. A portrait without real peak highlights reads as "filled" rather than "lit." This step separates amateur from professional work. Do not skip it, and do not apply white uniformly—apply it decisively where light actually strikes.*

18 Step 18: Burnish, Unify & Correct Darkened Values

Entire face, neck, and garment

Colorless blender at heavy pressure (burnish entire face); then re-deepen shadows with sharp pencil and light-to-medium pressure (correction); optional fixative

Heavy (burnishing), Light to Medium (shadow re-deepening) pressure

Burnishing is the final step and should NOT be done early. Using a colorless blender (PC1077) at heavy pressure, burnish smooth skin areas (forehead, cheeks, neck) to create a seamless, painted surface and eliminate paper tooth and visible pencil marks. Burnishing crushes the paper fiber and locks the layers together, but it also lightens the overall value (wax bloom). After burnishing, the highlights and mid-lit zones will appear lighter and more luminous, but the shadows and dark areas may appear washed out. This is where the correction comes in: using a sharp PC1099 Espresso or PC1076 90% French Grey at light-to-medium pressure, re-deepen the shadow zones (under jaw, eye sockets, away-side cheek, and any core shadows that lost depth) to restore the value range and form modeling lost to burnishing. Layer these darks in thin strokes, blending gently to avoid harsh edges. The hair should also be re-darkened in its shadow core after burnishing. Once this correction is complete, the portrait should read as cohesive, with full value range, luminous lit planes, and sculpted shadows. A final optional touch: a light fixative spray (Grumbacher matte or Lascaux) seals the pencil and prevents smudging.

COLORS

● PC1099 Espresso

● PC1076 90% French Grey

✦ *Burnishing is not the final step in technique—the shadow correction is. Do not call a portrait finished until you have restored the full value range after burnishing. This is the most commonly missed step and the difference between a portrait that reads as overworked/washed-out and one that reads as luminous and sculpted.*